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A RECONSIDERATION OF RICHARD HALLIBURTON'S INTERVIEW WITH P. Z. ERMAKOV AS EVIDENCE FOR THE MURDER OF THE ROMANOVs

Early in the morning of July 17, 1918, Tsar Nicholas II, his wife Aleksandra, their son Aleksei, their four daughters, Tat'iana, Ol'ga, Mariia, and Anastasia, plus four others, their physician, Dr. Botkin, the footman Trupp, the cook Kharitonov, and the maid Anna Demidova (a total of eleven people), were murdered by the Bolsheviks at Ekaterinburg in the Ural *Oblast'*. At the time, the Bolshevik government acknowledged only the death of Nicholas and indicated that the rest of the family was alive and in a safe place.¹ By the end of July, White Guards took over the town and surrounding area, but it was not until the winter that a formal investigation into the murders was begun. Ivan Sergeev, the district commissioner, took depositions that he turned over to his successor Nikolai Sokolov. After a thorough investigation, Sokolov concluded that the entire family had been killed and explained his inability to find the bodies by the fact that they had been burned with gasoline and completely destroyed through the use of sulphuric acid at the mine shaft where the personal effects of the family had been found.² The absence of bodies led to speculation that one or more members of the family had escaped. Recently,

1. *Izvestiia*, July 19, 1918, as cited in William Henry Chamberlin, *The Russian Revolution 1917-1921*, vol. 2, *1918-1921: From the Civil War to the Consolidation of Power* (New York: Macmillan, 1935), 92. See also the *Times* (London), July 22, 1918, as cited in Robert Wilton, *The Last Days of the Romanovs from 15th March, 1917* (London: Thornton Butterworth, 1920), 98-99; cf. George Gustav Telberg and Robert Wilton, *The Last Days of the Romanovs* (New York: George H. Doran, 1920), 322-23. It was not until 1921 that a Soviet source acknowledged the killing of the entire family. See P. M. Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednogo tsaria," in *Rabochaia revoliutsiia na Urale*, ed. N. I. Nikolaev (Ekaterinburg: Gosudarstvennoe izdatel'stvo, 1921), 21.

2. N. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i* (Berlin: Slovo, 1925), 218. Sokolov's conclusions had been previously published by Robert Wilton, a *Times* correspondent who was with the Sokolov Commission, and by General Diterikhs, who oversaw Sokolov's investigations. Wilton, *Last Days*, 101-02, 114-15; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 326-27, 344-45; Mikhail Konstantinovich Diterikhs, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i i chlenov Doma Romanovykh na Urale*, 2 vols. (Vladivostok: Tip. Voennoi akademii, 1922; reprinted with different pagination: Moscow: Skify, 1991).

the claim that the skulls and bones found at another location along the Ekaterinburg-Koptiaki road are those of five members of the family, their doctor, and three servants has been generally accepted.³ As a result, a wealth of evidence has appeared about the killings, but inconsistencies in the various stories have not been adequately resolved.

In 1935, Richard Halliburton, an American travel writer, published a dramatic interview with Petr Zakharovich Ermakov, one of the assassins of the Romanov family.⁴ Since its publication, Halliburton's account of the three-and-one-half-hour interview with Ermakov has been either overlooked or ignored or just dismissed out of hand. Among the doubts raised by those who dismiss his account are whether Halliburton actually interviewed Ermakov or obtained the information in some other way, and, if the interview did take place, whether Ermakov gave Halliburton accurate information. The result has been that the Halliburton interview is not well known, and those writing about the events of July 1918 in Ekaterinburg have tended not to use it.⁵ In

3. Edvard Radzinsky, *The Last Tsar: The Life and Death of Nicholas II*, trans. Marian Schwartz (New York: Doubleday, 1992), 435–38; "Czar's Remains Believed Found," *Facts on File*, May 28, 1992, 393–94; "Bones Are Identified as the Czar's," *New York Times*, June 23, 1992, A5(N), A9(L), col. 4; "Remains of Russian Czar, Czarina Positively Identified," *Boston Globe*, June 23, 1992, 2; "Royal DNA Matched with Russian Bones," *Boston Globe*, Dec. 11, 1992; John Darnton, "Scientists Confirm Identification of Bones as Czar's," *New York Times*, July 10, 1993, 3; John Darnton, "July 4–10: Royal Blood, Royal Bones: The Romanov Remains Are Finally Confirmed," *New York Times*, July 11, 1993, 2; Interview with Peter Gill of the National Forensic Institute, Birmingham, England, National Public Radio, Feb. 1, 1994; *Nicholas & Alexandra*, dir. Michael Beckham, Granada Television, 1994; and *Mystery of the Last Tsar*, dir. Victoria Lewis, Cymru Films, 1998.

4. Richard Halliburton, *Seven League Boots* (Indianapolis: Bobbs-Merrill, 1935), 100–55; reprinted by Garden City Publishing in 1937. A third edition appeared in 1941. Halliburton does not state when his interview with Ermakov occurred, but evidence in his letters to his parents indicates it was sometime in mid to late November 1934. He wrote a letter from Moscow dated Nov. 7, 1934, in which he states that he plans to go to Sverdlovsk "in a few days." Richard Halliburton, *His Story of His Life's Adventure as Told in Letters to His Mother and Father* (Indianapolis: Bobbs-Merrill, 1940), 358–59. In his next letter, dated Dec. 2, 1934, from Moscow, he states that his "Sverdlovsk expedition was a grand and glorious success, beyond my wildest hopes." He goes on to describe how he had interviewed "the actual assassin" and writes: "I'm still a little weak over the melodramatics of the thing." *Ibid.*, 359–60. He wrote up the story during the last two weeks of February 1935 in Athens, Greece. *Ibid.*, 364.

5. For example, none of the following treatments makes mention of the interview or of any evidence from that interview: Robert K. Massie, *Nicholas and Alexandra* (New York: Atheneum, 1968), 490–93 (514–16 in the Dell Publishing reprint); John F. O'Connor, "Translator's Commentary," in *The Sokolov Investigation of the Alleged Murder of the Russian Imperial Family* (New York: Robert Speller and Sons, 1971), 1–101; Marina Grey, *Enquête sur le massacre des Romanov* (Paris: Librairie Académique Perrin, 1987); *Gibel' tsarskoi sem'i. Materialy sledstviia po delu ob ubiistve tsarskoi sem'i (avgust 1918-fevral' 1920)*, ed. Nikolai Ross (Frankfurt am Main: Possev-Verlag, 1987); W. Bruce Lincoln, *Red Victory: A History of the Russian Civil War* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1989), 149–55; Dmitrii Borovikov and

this article, I will reexamine the issue of whether the Halliburton interview should continue to be dismissed and ignored. It is my hypothesis that the information Ermakov gave Halliburton in 1934 provides reliable evidence for the assassination of the Romanov family and, up to a point, for the ultimate disposal of their bodies. But first, let us look at the arguments that have been made for dismissing the Halliburton interview.

Anthony Summers and Tom Mangold, in their book *The File on the Tsar*, make the claim that the Romanovs were not killed at Ekaterinburg in July 1918. They call Halliburton's interview "a fantastical story."⁶ Furthermore, they characterize Halliburton's account as "packed with mistakes and contradictions." In attempting to discredit the evidence of the interview with Ermakov, they first try to discredit Halliburton himself. One of the contacts that Halliburton mentions was William Stoneman, who in 1934 was Moscow correspondent for the *Chicago Daily News*. According to Halliburton, Stoneman provided the tip that Ermakov was still alive and in Sverdlovsk. Summers and Mangold, in preparation for their book, contacted Stoneman in Paris and reported his assessment of Halliburton: "In my view, . . . he was the worst kind of phoney." According to them, Stoneman rejected Halliburton's account as being based on "pre-packaged 'facts'" fed to him by "an official Soviet interpreter."⁷ Summers and Mangold's main criticism of the Halliburton/Ermakov account, however, is that it contradicts evidence and testimony provided by others and that it has information not found in other accounts.

Dmitrii Gavrilov, "'Rasstreliany proletarskoi rukoi'. Eshche odin neizvestnyi dokument ob ubistve tsarskoi sem'i," *Ural*, no. 11 (1990): 173–78; Marc Ferro, *Nicholas II: The Last Tsar*, trans. Brian Pearce (Oxford: Oxford Univ. Press, 1993), 233–87 (first published in French by Editions Payot in 1990 and in English by Viking UK in 1991); Richard Pipes, *The Russian Revolution* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1990), 770–88; *Poslednie dni Romanovykh*, ed. A. N. Kazakevich (Moscow: Kniga, 1991); Iu. Buranov and V. Khrustal'ev, *Gibel' imperatorskogo doma 1917–1919 gg.* (Moscow: Progress, 1992), 256–74; and Dominic Lieven, *Nicholas II: Emperor of All the Russias* (London: John Murray, 1993), 242–46; Mark D. Steinberg and Vladimir M. Khrustal'ev, *The Fall of the Romanovs: Political Dreams and Personal Struggles in a Time of Revolution* (New Haven, CT: Yale Univ. Press, 1995), 277–366. Warth does cite the relevant chapters of Halliburton's book but then identifies them as "[i]nterviews with Yurovsky" and does not seem to use the information there in his reconstruction of events. Robert D. Warth, *Nicholas II: The Life and Death of Russia's Last Monarch* (Westport, CT: Praeger, 1997), 305 n. 53.

6. Anthony Summers and Tom Mangold, *The File on the Tsar* (London: Victor Gollancz, 1987), 176. They do mention, however, that Marvin Lyons, who published a picture biography of Nicholas II, is convinced of the authenticity of Halliburton's interview and at the time called it "the only first-hand account" of the murder (*ibid.*, 383). Nonetheless, Lyons did not make use of Halliburton's interview in his book. See Marvin Lyons, *Nicholas II: The Last Tsar* (New York: St. Martin's [also published in London by Routledge & Kegan Paul], 1974).

7. Summers and Mangold, *File on the Tsar*, 177.

They refer to testimony of Pavel Medvedev that Ermakov told him they used explosives at the Four Brothers mine shaft, and point out that Halliburton's Ermakov does not mention the use of explosives.⁸ They dispute the existence of a Bolshevik maid at the Ipatiev House, who, in the interview, Ermakov says he called out of the murder room at the last moment so she would not be killed. Summers and Mangold say flatly: "There was no such maid" at the Ipatiev House."⁹ Finally, they question the following statement in the Halliburton/Ermakov account:

We didn't leave the smallest pinch of ash on the ground. . . . I put the tins of ashes in the wagon again, and ordered the driver to take me back towards the highroad. . . . I pitched the ashes into the air — and the wind caught them like dust and carried them out across the woods and fields . . . and it rained the next day . . . so if anyone says he's seen a Romanov, or a piece of a dead one — tell him about the ashes and the wind and the rain.¹⁰

Summers and Mangold call this "nonsense" because "[t]here were of course piles of cinders left behind at the Four Brothers. . . ."¹¹ Despite these differences with other sources, they conclude that "[t]he whole Halliburton account could have been filched from existing sources."¹²

Since Summers and Mangold are trying to make the case that the Romanovs were not killed in Ekaterinburg, they need to discredit any testimony (such as the Halliburton/Ermakov account) that says they were. Their view is that where Halliburton's account coincides with other testimony, it is evidence that Halliburton "filched" from other sources, and where it differs from other testimony, it is evidence of mistakes in his account.

On examining their criticisms more closely, we can come to different, more plausible conclusions. Stoneman's accusation that Halliburton was fed "pre-packaged 'facts'" by "an official Soviet interpreter" is odd when we consider that Halliburton had hired Stoneman's own interpreter, Walter, to accompany and translate for him in Sverdlovsk.¹³ In addition, Stoneman's calling him "the worst kind of phoney" may have been a codified allusion to Halliburton's homosexuality. Finally, we can suggest other possible motives for Stoneman's opposition. Halliburton's biographer, Jonathan Root, reports the

8. Ibid., 383.

9. Ibid.

10. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 143–44.

11. Summers and Mangold, *File on the Tsar*, 177.

12. Ibid., 383.

13. See Jonathan Root, *Halliburton: The Magnificent Myth* (New York: Coward-McCann, 1965), 227.

following exchange between Stoneman and Halliburton in Moscow in December 1934:

"Halliburton," said Stoneman grinning, "you're a story teller posing as a journalist. The next thing you'll tell me is that Ermakov died in your arms."

"No," said Richard, "he didn't. As far as I know, he's still alive. Why don't you go to Sverdlovsk and talk to him yourself?"¹⁴

Stoneman might have seen in Halliburton's account an implicit criticism of his own journalistic abilities. After all, Stoneman was denied an interview with Ermakov, as Halliburton also says he was. But Halliburton, in his own account, persists, as Stoneman apparently did not. Halliburton travels to Sverdlovsk and phones the home of Ermakov, but is told by Ermakov's wife that he is too sick to be interviewed. After hanging up, Halliburton regrets having come so far with nothing to show for it. He calls back and asks for an interview with Ermakov's wife, which she assents to. It is only after Halliburton arrives at the house and begins asking Ermakov's wife questions that Ermakov, listening from the bed in the next room, interrupts with the statement, "*Tell him there were only three of us!*" (italics in original), and gives Halliburton his account of the murders and disposing of the bodies.¹⁵ Stoneman, like Halliburton, had been denied an interview with Ermakov, and, apparently for want of thinking of Halliburton's simple ploy, missed the scoop that Halliburton claims to have made.

The "contradictions" that Summers and Mangold refer to in the interview turn out to be external contradictions, that is, the evidence provided does not always correspond with evidence provided by others. They do not point out any internal contradictions in the story. Likewise, the "mistakes" that Halliburton's Ermakov was supposed to have made in the interview on closer inspection can be seen to be not mistakes but reliable information that Ermakov would have been one of the few people to have. The source for Summers and Mangold's information about explosives being used in the mine shaft was Medvedev's deposition made in 1919 to Ivan Sergeev, a member of the Ekaterinburg District Court, who investigated the murders before the Sokolov Commission did. According to Medvedev's deposition, Ermakov told him "that the bodies had been thrown down the shaft of a mine near the Verkh-Isetsk Works, and that the shaft had afterwards been destroyed by

14. Ibid., 231.

15. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 165–67.

bombs or explosives in order to fill it up.”¹⁶ The idea that explosives were used to cover up the bodies has been questioned before. General Diterikhs, for example, concluded that Ermakov must have been lying to Medvedev:

to destroy a mine shaft with the aid of hand grenades is absolutely impossible; it is sheer fantasy. An excellent example of this is the fact that the Nizhnii-Semichensk shaft, where not only hand grenades were exploded but also large artillery shells of considerable explosive force were dropped, was not successfully destroyed but sustained only the ripping out of separate planks from a part of the framework. In this respect, Ermakov was undoubtedly lying to Pavel Medvedev and, we must suppose, lied also when he said that they threw the bodies into the shafts.¹⁷

Yet, according to the official report of Iakov Iurovskii, who was in charge of the assassination, “hand grenades” (ручные гранаты) were used in an unsuccessful attempt to destroy the mine shaft where the bodies were first thrown on the morning of July 17.¹⁸ Iurovskii explained the finding of a woman’s finger at the Four Brothers mine by the Sokolov Commission as the result of some dismemberment from the use of those hand grenades. In another version, which Iurovskii told to a gathering of Old Bolsheviks in Sverdlovsk on February 1, 1934, he used the term “bombs” (бомбы) to describe the explosives used.¹⁹ Clearly, Ermakov had not lied to Medvedev, but he may have misled him into thinking that this was the end of the matter, and that the bodies were not then subsequently moved. Since Halliburton had access to a published version of Medvedev’s deposition (see below), there was no reason for him to leave out that information if he was merely filching his account from available sources. It is more likely Halliburton did not report it because Ermakov did not mention it. And, in speaking of the ultimate disposal of the bodies, Ermakov was right in not mentioning the explosives to Halliburton because they had nothing to do with it.

16. “The Examination of Pavel Medvedev,” in Wilton, *Last Days*, 292; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 204. This part of the deposition does not appear in Sokolov’s book. See Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem’i*, 237.

17. Diterikhs, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem’i*, 1:257 (reprint ed., 1: 242).

18. Ia. Iurovskii, “Zapiska,” published by Edvard Radzinskii, in “Rasstrel v Ekaterinburge,” *Ogonek*, no. 21 (May 1989): 31. According to Buranov and Khrustal’ev, Iurovskii wrote his account in 1920 for the historian M. N. Pokrovskii. Buranov and Khrustal’ev, *Gibel’ imperatorskogo doma*, 258.

19. “Iz rasskaza Ia. M. Iurovskogo o rasstrele tsarskoi sem’i na soveshchanii starykh bol’shevikov v g. Sverdlovske,” in V. V. Alekseev, *Gibel’ tsarskoi sem’i. Mify i real’nost’ (Novye dokumenty o tragedii na Urale)* (Ekaterinburg: Bank kul’turnoi infomatsii, 1993), 113.

In addition, the fact that one of the maids attending the Romanovs was a Bolshevik sent to spy on them would not have been widely known. It stands to reason that the Bolsheviks would have wanted someone close to the family to inform on their doings and conversations. In his official report, Iurovskii also mentions a twelfth person — besides the eleven mentioned above — another cook (повар) who was shot.²⁰ Edvard Radzinsky, who published Iurovskii's report in 1989, notes that Iurovskii was mistaken, and identifies this *povar* with the kitchen boy, Leonid Sednev.²¹ But Iurovskii had just indicated at the beginning of his report that he had sent "the boy" (without mentioning his name) away at six o'clock in the evening,²² so he must be referring to another *povar* here. Significantly, Iurovskii and Halliburton/Ermakov agree that there was a twelfth person who was led down to the murder room with the family. They differ on who that person was and whether that person was killed at the time. It seems unlikely that Halliburton would have concocted such a person, since he did not have access to Iurovskii's report and no one else mentions a twelfth person. And if Halliburton did have access to Iurovskii's report or knew somehow of its contents, he would not have differed with it so blatantly on who that twelfth person was and whether that person was shot. Most likely this represents a difference in memory of the event between Ermakov and Iurovskii themselves. Since Iurovskii was mistaken about whether that person was shot, it seems likely Iurovskii was the one who confused the maid with a cook and not Ermakov who confused the cook with a maid.

Finally, Summers and Mangold dismiss the claim that the ashes of the cremated bodies were thrown to the winds. They point out that "*piles* of cinders" were found at the Four Brothers mine shaft. In doing so, they ignored two significant considerations. First, Sokolov reported that, except for one finger, no evidence of remains of bodies could be found at the Four Brothers — only clothes, jewelry, and assorted items.²³ Second, Halliburton's Ermakov makes it clear that he took the remains of the bodies some 2 km further along the road toward Koptiaki where he then used gasoline and sulphuric acid to destroy what remained of the bodies:

20. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 31. In his 1934 retelling, Iurovskii does not mention a specific number of people brought down to the room. See "Iz rasskaza," 109–10.

21. Radzinskii, "Rasstrel v Ekaterinburge," 31 n. 8.

22. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 31. Pavel Medvedev had told Alekseev, an agent of the Criminal Investigation Division, that "during the morning of that day, Iurovskii had arranged for the removal of the boy who was the waiter's nephew from the house to the guards' quarters in the neighboring Popov House." Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 230 (see also p. 234 and Wilton, *Last Days*, 288; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 199). Iurovskii, in his 1934 account, also says that he sent the boy away in the morning of the sixteenth. "Iz rasskaza," 109.

23. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 206–18. See also Sokolov *Investigation*, 176–91.

Here in the mouth of this mine we built a funeral pyre of cut logs big enough to hold the bodies, two layers deep. We poured five tins of gasoline over the corpses, and two buckets of sulphuric acid, and set the logs afire. The gasoline made everything burn rapidly. But I stood by to see that not one fingernail or fragment of bone remained unconsumed. Anything of that sort the Whites found I knew they would use as a holy relic. I kept pushing back into the flames whatever pieces were left, and building more fire, and pouring on more gasoline. We had to keep the fire burning a long time to burn up the skulls. But I wasn't satisfied till our pyre and everything upon it was reduced to powder.²⁴

It was these ashes that Ermakov claimed he threw to the winds, not the ashes at the Four Brothers. Thus, the reasons Summers and Mangold give for rejecting the Halliburton/Ermakov account are insubstantial.

Edvard Radzinsky likewise dismisses Halliburton's account. Although he does not dispute that Halliburton interviewed Ermakov, he questions Ermakov's motives for talking with Halliburton and he questions Halliburton's claim that Ermakov was dying of throat cancer:

As always, though, there were two models: "for them" and "for us." For them, that is, for the "progressive world public," everything remained as before: the execution of the bloody despot, the holy vengeance of the people's revolution. That was why when the journalist Richard Halliburton turned up in Sverdlovsk in the 1930s, Peter Ermakov willingly told him about the execution of the Romanovs and about how he personally had shot the tsar. But we know that without the permission of the "serious institution" a meeting with a foreign journalist would have been impossible. The sly Chekist explained this by his throat cancer — he was giving his dying testament, so to speak. Ermakov laughed when he lived to thrive another twenty years after that. He had borrowed the "throat cancer" from one of his friends in the Ural Soviet, a friend whom we will talk about again.²⁵

What Radzinsky seems to be alluding to here is a perception that the Soviet government willingly provided information to foreigners about the assassination that it withheld from Soviet citizens. Yet, Halliburton's interview with Ermakov is the only known testimony that any foreigner obtained about the murders and disposing of the bodies, and the only eyewitness testimony between 1920, when the *Times* correspondent Robert Wilton published transla-

24. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 143.

25. Radzinsky, *The Last Tsar*, 396–97.

tions of the depositions as a result of his work with the Sokolov Commission, and 1989, when Radzinsky himself published Iurovskii's account.

The idea that the Soviet government was keeping information about the murders from Soviet citizens that it was telling foreigners would seem to be contradicted by at least three considerations. First, P. M. Bykov, former chairman of the Ural Soviet at Ekaterinburg, had published an article in 1921 and a book in 1926, both of them in the Soviet Union, on the shooting of the Romanovs.²⁶ Second, the Sokolov Commission reported that "several times the Soviet press has attempted to give Ermakov the role of leader in the murder."²⁷ Third, Radzinsky himself further on the same page quotes from a letter by Aleksei Karelin, who remembered that Ermakov, "one of the 'heroes' who participated in the execution of the tsar's family," spoke to a group of Young Pioneers in Cheliabinsk in 1934 or 1935 about the assassination.²⁸ So, it would seem the Soviet government and press were more forthcoming with information for internal than for external consumption.

Furthermore, according to Halliburton's account, it does not appear that Ermakov so "willingly" granted the interview. It is also not clear why, if Ermakov had official approval, he would resort to the ruse of throat cancer to explain why he was granting it. Instead, in the Halliburton account, the throat cancer is used as a reason why Ermakov could not grant the interview. Radzinsky claims that Ermakov could not have been on his deathbed at the time of the interview, as Halliburton claims, because Ermakov died in 1952, at which time a street was named in his honor in Sverdlovsk.²⁹ If Ermakov was not dying of throat cancer in the early 1930s, then the symptoms Halliburton witnessed could have been those of a less lethal illness, such as pneumococcal pneumonia, from which it is possible to recover even after spitting blood.³⁰ Stomach ulcers could also cause spitting of blood and not be fatal. Neither pneumonia nor stomach ulcers, however, would ordinarily require a blood

26. Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednego tsaria," 3–26; and P. M. Bykov, *Poslednie dni Romanovykh* (Sverdlovsk: Uralkniga, 1926). It may be significant, however, that some of the information found in the article does not appear in the book. See the translator's footnotes to P. M. Bikov [Bykov], *Les derniers jours des Romanov*, trans. G. Sidamon-Eristov (Paris: Payot, 1931), esp., 152.

27. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 240. This may refer in part to Bykov's 1921 article, which declared that Ermakov was assigned "organization of the shooting and destruction of the bodies." Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednego tsaria," 20.

28. Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 397.

29. Ibid., 429; see also Borovikov and Gavrillov, "Rasstreliany proletarskoi rukoi," 173–74.

30. Isadore Rosenfield, *Symptoms* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1989), 126. Any strenuous or chronic coughing can rupture blood vessels in the back of the throat, and thus cause bleeding (ibid., 220).

transfusion, which is what Halliburton reported Ermakov had.³¹ For reasons that I will discuss below, I have come to the conclusion that Ermakov did die shortly after his interview with Halliburton in 1934.

Radzinsky goes on to state that Ermakov had previously written an "Autobiography" (signed August 3, 1932) and lived to write his "Memoirs," which were deposited in the Sverdlovsk Party Archives in 1947.³² The "Memoirs" were published in their entirety in 1990 by Dmitrii Borovikov and Dmitrii Gavrillov.³³ Radzinsky claims he obtained a copy of the "Autobiography" and "Memoirs" from an anonymous "guest." Radzinsky's "guest" evaluated the testimony of the "Autobiography" and "Memoirs" this way: "if we toss out that boastful invention, then the memoirs represent a garbled compilation of well-known facts. As soon as he gets to the details the mistakes begin."³⁴ Thus, Radzinsky accepts the "Memoirs" of 1947 as Ermakov's true version, although he admits it is full of mistakes, and rejects what Ermakov told Halliburton in 1934 as being false, although he does not point out any errors in that account.

What I would like to do at this point is walk the reader through the maze of conflicting source testimony by asking and discussing a series of questions concerning the events of July 16 through July 18, 1918, in Ekaterinburg. By comparing the evidence, point by point, the reader can decide the relative reliability of the sources (see table). When we compare the account of the "Memoirs" of the events leading up to the shooting and the shooting itself with the Halliburton/Ermakov account of those events, we find they differ on almost every point.

The "Memoirs" report: "I received the orders on July 16 at eight o'clock in the evening. . . ."³⁵ Halliburton/Ermakov says: "It was on July twelfth we had our final meeting and got our orders. We set the night of July sixteenth for the shooting — four days later."³⁶ The "Memoirs" report that he (Ermakov) came to the house with "Medvedev and another Latvian who served under

31. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 105. Of course, Ermakov could have misled Halliburton about the transfusion.

32. For the "Autobiography," see *fond 41, op. 2, d. 79*; and for the "Memoirs," see archive 221, list 2, file 774.

33. See "Vospominaniia" in Borovikov and Gavrillov, "Rasstreliany proletarskoi rukoi," 178–83. The part concerning the shooting of the family was reprinted in *Poslednie dni Romanovykh. Dokumenty, materialy sledstviia, dnevniki, versii* (Sverdlovsk: Sredne-Ural'skoe knizhnoe izdatel'stvo, 1991), 162–65. My thanks to Richard Pipes for bringing this last item to my attention and for providing me with a photocopy of it.

34. Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 399.

35. "Vospominaniia," 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 399.

36. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 131.

me in my detachment — in the punitive section.”³⁷ Halliburton's Ermakov says he made all his preparations with Vaganov, and makes no mention of Medvedev or anyone else helping him.³⁸ The “Memoirs” report: “I arrived at ten o'clock at the house of specified designation (особого назначения); my vehicle, a small type of truck, came soon after.”³⁹ Halliburton's Ermakov says that he was in the Ipatiev house already during the afternoon when he helped Iurovskii determine in which room the killings should take place. He does not mention leaving the house until: “About midnight Vaganof and I drove in the truck to the far side of the Cathedral Square, and left it there with some soldiers. I told the driver to come to the basement entrance at the side of the house when I sent for him.”⁴⁰

The “Memoirs” report: “At eleven o'clock it was proposed to the Romanovs and their people to go downstairs to the lower floor.”⁴¹ Halliburton/Ermakov says the Romanov family was awakened later, shortly after midnight (when he and Vaganov had returned from parking the truck on the other side of the square) but before 1:00 A.M. (at which time Iurovskii began to get impatient at how long the family was taking).⁴² The “Memoirs” report:

To this proposal there was the question: “What for?” I said: “They will take you to the center, it is impossible to keep you here any longer, danger threatens.” “What about our things?” they asked. I said: “We will collect your things and give them to you.” They agreed.⁴³

Halliburton's Ermakov, in contrast, says nothing to the family when they are awakened; Iurovskii does the talking:

Yurovsky then knocked on the Czar's door. The Czarina and Alexis were sleeping in the same room. Yurovsky woke them up and went in. I stood just outside.

He told them that a lot of fighting had broken out in the town, and was spreading this way. For their own security they must dress and collect in the guard-room by the basement entrance. An automobile would

37. “Vospominaniia,” 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400. Radzinsky adds in parentheses the phrase “I don't remember his name now” after the word “Latvian.”

38. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 132–34.

39. “Vospominaniia,” 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400.

40. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 133–34.

41. “Vospominaniia,” 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400. Radzinsky adds the adjective “imprisoned” before “Romanovs” and the phrase “confined with them” after “their people.”

42. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 134–35.

43. “Vospominaniia,” 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400.

come there to pick them up, and take them to other quarters — at least for the night.⁴⁴

Halliburton's Ermakov does make an offer to carry Aleksei when the family leaves their bedrooms, but Nicholas turns him down, preferring to carry Aleksei himself.⁴⁵

The "Memoirs" report that in the basement room "chairs were placed for them along the wall. It is well preserved in my memory: in the first rank sat Nicholas, Aleksei, Aleksandra, the older daughter Tat'iana, in the next [rank] sat Dr. Botkin, then the lady-in-waiting (фрейлина), and in the next, all the rest."⁴⁶ Halliburton's Ermakov says that there were two chairs in the middle of the room and a third chair by the right-hand wall and places the individuals differently in the room:

There were only three chairs in the room — no other furniture.

Alexis was seated on one chair in the middle of the room — he was still so sick he couldn't stand.

The Czar had another chair and was sitting beside Alexis.

The Czarina sat just under the window, by the right-hand wall, with Anastasia standing beside her. . . . I'd nailed the window down to help muffle the shots.

Dr. Botkin stood right behind the Czarevitch. Anna, the maid, was standing in the far right-hand corner, clutching her two pillows; the cook and valet together in the left-hand corner.

Leaning against the back wall were Olga, Tatiana and Maria. None of the girls had on hats or coats.

In the left corner by the door was the Bolshevik maid.⁴⁷

The "Memoirs" report: "Everyone seated waited for something to happen. For everyone it was a tense situation and they occasionally exchanged words. Aleksandra said some words not in Russian."⁴⁸ Halliburton's Ermakov reports exactly the opposite when the family was walking down the stairs to

44. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 134.

45. *Ibid.*, 135.

46. "Vospominaniia," 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400. The author of the "Memoirs" could have derived the term from Bykov's account, in which the word фрейлина is used to describe Demidova. Iakimov testified in his deposition that фрейлина is what the guards called Demidova. Wilton, *Last Days*, 270; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 175. Iurovskii uses the term both in his 1920 report ("Zapiska," 30) and in his 1934 account ("Iz rasskaza," 111) to apply to Demidova.

47. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 136–37.

48. "Vospominaniia," 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400.

the room: "Nobody seemed excited. I'm sure they didn't suspect. The Czar was saying something in English I couldn't understand."⁴⁹

The "Memoirs" have Ermakov taking charge of the shooting, while Iurovskii demurs at killing the entire family:

When everything had settled down, I went out and told the driver: "Get going." He knew what needed to be done, the truck began to honk (zahu-dela). . . . When everything was in order, I gave to the house commandant, Yurovsky, in his office, the Oblast Executive Committee's order. He was doubtful: "But why all?" But I told him: "We have to do all of them, and we can't go on talking here any longer, time is short, it's time to begin." I went downstairs with the commandant.⁵⁰

Halliburton's Ermakov, in contrast, has Iurovskii clearly in charge:

In a minute or two Yourovsky came back, and told Vaganof and me that the time had come to kill. I said we mustn't forget the truck. I sent a guard across the square to tell the driver to come on at once to the side entrance — and not to forget about the motor noise.⁵¹

The author of the "Memoirs" seems to contradict himself at this point about Iurovskii's being informed at the last minute that they all were to be shot, for the account continues: "I must say that it had already been decided earlier who was to shot whom and how. I myself took Nicholas himself, Aleksandra, the daughter, and Aleksei, because I had a Mauser, and it was possible to work accurately with it. The rest had Nagants."⁵² According to Halliburton's Ermakov: "Yourovsky told Vaganof and me not to shoot at the Czar or the Czarevitch — *he* wanted them. I was to get the Czarina, Dr. Botkin, the cook and the valet. Vaganof would kill the four girls and the Czarina's personal maid."⁵³

49. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 135.

50. "Vospominaniia," 182; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400. The author of the "Memoirs" may have obtained this idea from Bykov's account, which puts Ermakov, not Iurovskii, in charge of "the organization of the shooting and the destruction of the shot bodies. . . ." Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednogo tsaria," 20.

51. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 136. Here Ermakov's account differs from both Iurovskii's 1920 report and 1934 account. Iurovskii indicates that he was annoyed the truck was not already there. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 31; "Iz rasskaza," 109. Ermakov would have downplayed the significance of Iurovskii's impatience with him for not having the truck by saying it was he, Ermakov, who remembered the truck and by attributing Iurovskii's impatience to the delay of the Romanovs in getting ready.

52. "Vospominaniia," 182–83; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400.

53. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 137 (italics in original).

The two accounts of the actual shooting also differ significantly. The "Memoirs" report:

After coming down to the lower floor, we delayed a little. Then the commandant suggested everyone stand. Everyone stood, but Aleksei sat in a chair. Then he began reading the sentence-resolution, where it said: "By resolution of the Executive Committee they are to be shot." Then Nicholas burst out the phrase: "So they are not taking us anywhere?" (как нас никуда не повезут?). It was impossible to wait any longer, and I shot him point blank. He fell immediately, but also the others as well. At that time a wail rose among them, they threw themselves on each other's necks. Then several shots rang out — and everyone fell. When I began to examine their condition, those who were still alive I shot again. Nicholas died from a single bullet, his wife got two, and the others also several bullets.⁵⁴

The words the "Memoirs" attribute to Nicholas coincide almost exactly with what Bykov wrote in 1921: "так нас никуда не повезут?" and may, therefore, derive from that account.⁵⁵ One also notes that in this passage everyone except Nicholas falls twice, once after Nicholas is shot and a second time after they begin wailing and more shots ring out. What follows is the Halliburton/Ermakov account of the shooting. One might well question how a "[c]oughing, strangling and suffering" man as Halliburton describes Ermakov could present such a cogent account. But Halliburton explains: "His revelations, however, cannot possibly be recorded verbatim from this point, for they came out in disconnected phrases. But the facts of his story, rearranged in proper sequence, are correctly reported."⁵⁶ I present it in full in all its gruesome detail, editing out only Halliburton's commentary on Ermakov's coughing, spitting, and wheezing while telling the story:

We got to the corridor before the truck reached the side entrance, but we heard it coming.

The family heard it too. The Czar stood up. Alexis put on his cap. The valet reached for the pillow on the Czar's chair to take it along.

The truck stopped outside — not fifteen feet away from us — right in front of the basement door. The driver began to race his old war-torn engine, faster — faster — faster — till it fairly roared.

Yurovsky and Vaganof and I moved to the guardroom door.

54. "Vospominaniia," 183; Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 400.

55. Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednogo tsaria," 21.

56. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 131.

I beckoned to the Bolshevik maid. As she walked out I said something about putting her first in the automobile.

The others scarcely noticed it.

Then Yourovsky took a step forward into the room, and faced the Romanoffs — the death sentence in his hand. . . .

Yourovsky and Vaganof and I stood in the doorway. The commissars and guards stood just outside in the corridor. Yourovsky began to read the death sentence. He had to shout to be heard above the pounding of the truck motor just outside. . . . [ellipses in original text]

"You think the Whites are going to rescue you — but they aren't.

You think you're going away to England, and be a Czar again — well, you're not.

The Soviet of the Urals sentences you and your family to death for your crimes against the Russian people."

The Czarina understood — instantly. She jumped up and stood rigid. The others understood likewise. But they were all too stunned to speak. Only the Czar seemed not to comprehend. "What? — what?" he shouted back at Yourovsky over the roar of the engine, " — aren't we going to get out of here after all?"

Yourovsky's answer was to fire his pistol straight into the Czar's face.

The bullet went right through his brain.

The Czar spun to the floor and never moved. . . .

I fired my Mauser at the Czarina — only six feet away — couldn't miss. Got her in the mouth. In two seconds she was dead.

I fired next at Dr. Botkin. He'd thrown up his hands, and turned his face half away. The bullet went through his neck. He fell over backwards.

Yourovsky had shot the Czarevitch out of his chair, and he lay on the floor, groaning.

The cook was crouching in the corner. I got him in the body and then in the head. The valet went down. I don't know who shot him.

Vaganof made a clean sweep of the girls. They were in a heap on the floor, moaning and dying. He kept pouring bullets into Olga and Tatiana.

The two younger girls — Maria and Anastasia — had fallen beside Dr. Botkin.

The light was bad and smoke filled the room, so our aim wasn't always sure. Somebody must have crawled all the way forward to the corner beside the doorway — perhaps the valet. We later found bullet holes in the baseboard there.

I don't think any of us hit Anna, the maid. She had slid down in her corner and hidden behind her two pillows. We found afterward that the pillows were crammed with jewels — maybe the jewel cases turned the bullets away. But one of the guards got her through the throat with his bayonet . . . [ellipses in original text] we had called in our Cheka executioners from the corridor to help finish off the job, and they were clubbing and bayoneting everybody.

The Czarevitch wasn't dead . . . [ellipses in original text] still groaning and twisting on the floor. Yourovsky shot him twice more in the head. That finished him.

Anastasia was still alive too. A guard pushed her over on her back. She shrieked — he beat her to death with his rifle butt. . . . [ellipses in original text]⁵⁷

The only points of agreement here between the "Memoirs" and the interview are: that Iurovskii read the death sentence, that Nicholas responded with a question, that Ermakov had a Mauser,⁵⁸ and that he shot Aleksandra. Otherwise, the two accounts differ in almost every detail.

57. Ibid., 137–41.

58. The Mauser that is referred to here was a 7.63 mm semiautomatic pistol that held up to 10 rounds. The first model was introduced in 1896. Frederick Myatt, *Modern Small Arms: An Illustrated Encyclopedia of Famous Firearms from 1873 to the Present Day* (London: Salamander, 1978), 220–21; John Walter, ed., *Guns of the First World War: Rifles, Handguns and Ammunition, from the Text Book of Small Arms, 1909* (London: Greenhill, 1988), 231–32 (and 225–26 on the Nagant revolver, which is the kind of gun Vaganov and the guards in the outer room had). Of the 22 bullets taken from the back wall and floor of the basement room, Sokolov's anonymous expert was able to make some kind of identification of 18 bullets. Of these 18, he identified 11 as coming from a revolver. Of these 11, the expert identified 7 from a Nagant; the other 4 were of undetermined origin. Two other of the 18 identified bullets could have come from either a revolver or a semi-automatic (Sokolov writes "automatic," but there were no fully automatic pistols at the time). Four of the bullets he positively identifies as coming from semi-automatics — one of American manufacture, one from a Colt .45, one from a "Browning type," and one from a semi-automatic of undetermined type. Thus, the expert positively identified four guns that the bullets came from: (1) a Nagant revolver; (2) a Colt .45; (3) an American-manufactured semi-automatic; and (4) a Browning semi-automatic. It is likely the last two are the same weapon, that is, the Mauser, which uses a kind of bullet similar to that used by the Browning — a three-line bullet. This consideration also rules out the possibility that the semi-automatic of American manufacture is the same as the Colt .45, since the Colt uses a 4 1/2-line bullet. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 173–79. Sokolov chose not to pursue the question of what types of weapons were used, but the physical evidence points to handguns not rifles. Radzinskii published a document from around 1927 in which Iurovskii states he is donating two of the murder weapons to the Museum of the Revolution. According to the document, the Colt was Iurovskii's weapon ("I killed Nicholas on the spot with my Colt . . .") and the Mauser was used by his "assistant" (he blames his assistant's inexperience with the Mauser for why Aleksei

In each instance where the testimony can be checked, the Halliburton/Ermakov account coincides more or less exactly with other reliable sources, whereas the account in the "Memoirs" does not coincide with them at all. In particular, we have the eyewitness testimonies of two people that are more reliable than any of the others. (I am making a distinction here between those who claimed to have witnessed directly what they are describing and those who only claimed to have heard it from someone else. The latter testimony constitutes hearsay evidence and tends to be less reliable than the former.) Pavel Medvedev provided two versions (one that he told the agent Alekseev, the other in his deposition to Sergeev) that almost completely coincide with each other about the events immediately leading up to the shooting and the events immediately following the shooting.⁵⁹ The two versions of Medvedev's testimony coincide so closely that Summers and Mangold claim that Sokolov, in his book, merely converted the third-person narration of the Alekseev report to first person.⁶⁰ In this, however, they are confused. Sokolov presents both Medvedev's testimony to Alekseev (third-person narration) and Medvedev's deposition to Sergeev (first-person narration). And the two versions do differ on a few details that may be small but are important for our comparison with the Halliburton/Ermakov account. Medvedev did not take part in the shooting itself, so his testimony about what happened at that point is less trustworthy. Nor was he present at the disposal of the bodies, information about which he obtained from Ermakov. The other eyewitness testimony is that of Iurovskii, who, in addition to the events immediately before the shooting, also covers the shooting itself and discusses the disposal of the bodies. It is important to remember that, while Medvedev's account would have been available to Halliburton in 1934–35, Iurovskii's report would not have been, since it was hidden away in a state archive and not published until 1989. Iurovskii also spoke about the shooting to a gathering of Old Bolsheviks on February 1, 1934, an account of which was written down at the time, but also kept in a state archive and not published until 1993.

survived the initial barrage). Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 373. My thanks to Genghis LaPointe for clarifying for me a number of issues involving guns and ammunition of the time.

59. The version that Medvedev told Alekseev can be found in Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 230–33. An abridged version of the deposition to Sergeev can be found in *ibid.*, 233–37. Wilton published an English translation of the entire Medvedev deposition to Sergeev. See Wilton, *Last Days*, 285–93; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 195–205. Whether intentionally or not, Wilton's translation contains a significant lacuna.

60. Summers and Mangold, *File on the Tsar*, 117–18. They should not have made this mistake since they had access to the Houghton Library typescripts of both the Alekseev Report and the deposition to Sergeev (*ibid.*, 372 n.). Their mistake can be attributed to their attempt to discredit Sokolov in any way they could, even to the point of overlooking evidence that runs contrary to their intent.

Medvedev reported that he learned of the assassination plans only on the evening of July 16. And Iurovskii wrote in his account that on July 16 he received from Perm a telegram that contained the order (приказ) for the execution. But what Iurovskii received on July 16 was the statement he was to read to Nicholas, not the original order to execute the family. The original order came earlier, possibly on July 12, as Halliburton's Ermakov states, when Isaac Goloshchekin returned to Ekaterinburg from Moscow with the decision.⁶¹ Medvedev reported that Iurovskii woke the family around midnight,⁶² which coincides with what Ermakov told Halliburton. Iurovskii reports that the truck was supposed to arrive at midnight at which time the family was to be awakened. But the truck did not arrive until 1:30 A.M. while the family still slept.⁶³ The difference in the designated time between, on the one hand, Iurovskii's 1920 report and his 1934 account and, on the other, the accounts of Medvedev and Halliburton/Ermakov can be explained by the fact that on May 30 the Bolsheviks had ordered a change to daylight savings time for the summer two hours ahead of the standard time.⁶⁴ Some people tended to continue to think in terms of the old time.

Medvedev mentions Ermakov's return to the house at this point: "when Iurovskii went to awaken the Imperial family, two members of the Extraordi-

61. Sokolov wrote that Goloshchekin returned to Ekaterinburg "around July 14." Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 245. But see Pipes, *Russian Revolution*, 773. Bykov, who as a member and subsequent head of the Ural Oblast Soviet was in a position to know, wrote that the decision to kill the family was made "during the first days of July." Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednogo tsaria," 20. On Bykov's position at the time of the assassination, see O'Connor, "Translator's Commentary," 94 n. 19. Iurovskii calls Goloshchekin "Filip." See Iurovskii, "Zapiski," 30 and "Iz rasskaza," 108–14.

62. Wilton, *Last Days*, 289; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 200. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 231, 234. Bykov placed the going downstairs of the family at "around 10 o'clock in the evening." Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednogo tsaria," 21.

63. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 31; idem, "Iz rasskaza," 109.

64. See the testimony of Anatolii Iakimov. The English translation of Iakimov's testimony about this in Wilton, *Last Days*, 278 does not make sense and is mistaken: "they say it was at one o'clock a.m. by the Old Time, or a little past two by the New Time that had been instituted by the Bolsheviks, who changed the time two hours ahead. . . ." The English translation in Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 186 makes sense but is still mistaken: "they say it was a little past midnight by the Old Time, or a little past two by the New Time (instituted by the Bolsheviks, who changed the time two hours ahead). . . ." The correct translation is: "they say it was one o'clock a.m. by the old time or three o'clock by the new time, which the Bolsheviks had changed to two hours ahead." See Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 225: "по ихъ словамъ, въ первомъ часу ночи, считая по старому времени или въ третьемъ часу по новому времени, которое большевики перевели тогда на два часа впередъ." Nicholas recorded in his diary the change of time under May 23/June 5. *Dnevnik Imperatora Nikolaia II*, ed. V. P. Kozlov; T. F. Pavlova and Z. I. Peregodova (Moscow: Orbita, 1991), 681. Aleksandra recorded it in her diary under May 22/June 4. *The Last Diary of Tsaritsa Alexandra*, ed. Vladimir A. Kozlov and Vladimir M. Khrustal'ev (New Haven, CT: Yale Univ. Press, 1997), 156.

nary Commission came to the Ipatiev house: one, as it turned out later, was Petr Ermakov, and the other was unknown to me by first or last name."⁶⁵ This information appears only in Medvedev's depositions and would seem to refer to the return of Ermakov and Vaganov to the house after parking the truck on the other side of the square. The part of the statement that mentions Ermakov by name does not appear in the translated versions of the deposition that Wilton published in either the British or American editions.⁶⁶ Although Halliburton could have had access to one or the other Wilton version of Medvedev's deposition in order to "filch" information, he would have had to have obtained this particular information from the French, rather than Russian, edition of Sokolov's book because he could not read Russian.⁶⁷ If Halliburton obtained the information that Ermakov and someone else (name unknown) returned to the house after midnight from Medvedev's depositions in the French edition,⁶⁸ then he would have had to infer that the person accompanying him was Stepan Vaganov from another part of Sokolov's report, which states that Vaganov was Ermakov's assistant.⁶⁹

In the Alekseev version of his deposition, Medvedev states that, when the family left their rooms, "all of them were calm in appearance and as though they did not expect any danger."⁷⁰ This phrasing does not appear in the Sergeev version, where, in the Russian edition and in Wilton's English translation, there is only the statement: "While I was present no member of the Imperial Family asked any questions of anyone. Also there were no tears, no sobbing."⁷¹ Significantly, the French edition does not carry this sentence.⁷² Thus, Halliburton could not have derived this information from any versions of Medvedev's testimony available to him and most likely obtained the idea

65. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 234 (cf. 231).

66. See Wilton, *Last Days*, 289; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 200.

67. Halliburton indicates in his account that he knew of Sokolov's investigation, but he does not explicitly state that he read it. We can conclude from the nature of his remarks that he did so. For example, he called the investigation "a masterpiece of its kind" (*Seven League Boots*, 103) and he specifies that 65 "items" were found at the Four Brothers mine shaft (*ibid.*, 148). This indicates that he read the French edition because that edition lists 65 items found while the Russian edition lists 66 items. The German edition does not list the items found. Nicolas Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire sur l'assassinat de la famille impériale russe* (Paris: Payot, 1924), 244–53; Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 206–17; N. Sokoloff, *Der Todesweg des Zaren. Dargestellt von dem Untersuchungsrichter* (Berlin: Otto Stollberg, Verlag für Politik und Wirtschaft, 1925).

68. Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire*, 265, 268.

69. *Ibid.*, 272; Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 239.

70. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 231; Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire*, 265.

71. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 234. See also Wilton, *Last Days*, 289; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 200.

72. Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire*, 268.

that they were not excited or suspicious from Ermakov, who saw the same thing that Medvedev saw.

A small but significant difference between Medvedev's depositions occurs at this point. In the deposition to Sergeev, Medvedev states that the "maid had a pillow in her arms."⁷³ But in the statement to Alekseev, he says: "the maid carried two pillows."⁷⁴ This coincides with Halliburton/Ermakov that "Anna, the Czarina's maid, came out with *two pillows*" (italics in original).⁷⁵ Even if one begins to suspect at this point that Halliburton was "filching" from the French edition of the Sokolov report and supplementing it with the English translation of the depositions, one should also understand that, although Halliburton was an individual who was extraordinary at finding stories and in describing what he heard and saw, he was no scholar. He was a great travel writer, but an analyst he was not. One reviewer of his book remarked that Halliburton had a tendency to the "superficial" and was intellectually "vapid."⁷⁶ Nor did he have a burning desire to do what we would call "library research." For him to sort through the mass of contradictory information about the Romanov murders, piecing together fragments from here and there, in French and English translations, adding his own conjectures, and come up with a plausible, reliable account would have been highly unlikely. Even today, scholars, who supposedly have these analytical skills, have not been able to do so. Halliburton needed someone who was there to provide him such an account, and that person could only have been Ermakov.

One of the points to emphasize here is that the Halliburton/Ermakov account may be more accurate in some details than either Iurovskii's 1920 report or his 1934 account. I have already argued that Halliburton/Ermakov was more accurate in regard to the identity of the twelfth person and whether that person was shot with the rest. There are also other small but significant differences with Iurovskii's account that show to the advantage of the Halliburton interview. For example, Iurovskii reported that when Aleksandra asked for chairs, he ordered that two be brought in: "on one Nicholas placed Aleksei, on the other sat Aleksandra."⁷⁷ Both Medvedev and Halliburton/Ermakov, however, report that three chairs were brought into the room, one each for Nicholas, Aleksandra, and Aleksei.⁷⁸ Even if Iurovskii ordered only two chairs

73. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 235; Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire*, 268. See also Wilton, *Last Days*, 290; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 201.

74. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 231; Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire*, 265.

75. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 135.

76. See the review of *Seven League Boots* in the *Saturday Review of Literature*, 18 Jan. 1936, 18.

77. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 31; idem, "Iz rasskaza," 110.

78. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 231, 235. Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire*, 265–66, 268. See also Wilton, *Last Days*, 289; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 201.

brought in, it makes sense that the three principal members of the family — the tsar, the tsaritsa, and the tsarevich — would have chairs. Both Iurovskii and Halliburton/Ermakov agree that Nicholas was standing when Iurovskii read the death sentence to him, which may be why Iurovskii thought Nicholas had no chair. Note that none of these eyewitness testimonies corroborates that of the “Memoirs” that all the victims had chairs.

At this point, Iurovskii told Medvedev to go out into the street, so he did not witness the shooting. It may be for that reason that Medvedev thought that all eleven people in the outer room took part in the shooting. According to the Halliburton/Ermakov account only three — Iurovskii, Ermakov, and Vaganov — were in the room with the victims when the shooting began. The other eight remained in the outer room and came in only to dispose of those who were still alive after the initial barrage of gunfire. In his 1920 report, Iurovskii does not specify how many took part in the initial shooting in the room, referring only to “the detachment” (команд).⁷⁹ In his 1934 account, he says that some of those who remained in the outer room “apparently shot across the threshold.”⁸⁰ He says “apparently” because of the bullets that were ricocheting around the room, one of which whizzed past his ear. Of interest is the fact that Bykov reported that “only four people were present at the execution, those who fired on the victims.”⁸¹ The Halliburton/Ermakov scenario of three executioners is more plausible than eleven executioners in such close quarters with eleven victims. As Ermakov told Halliburton: “There was a double door leading from the end of the room into the basement corridor. We executioners would have to stand in the doorway and fire at the family all crowded together in the small room. If there were more than three of us we’d be in one another’s way.”⁸² Medvedev’s wife testified to the Sokolov Commission that Medvedev told her that he was one of twelve executioners.⁸³ Apparently Medvedev, in bragging to his wife, added himself to the eleven he thought had done the shooting. Bykov may have heard about Medvedev’s claim and added him as a fourth to the three who he heard had done the shooting.⁸⁴ Halliburton’s Ermakov confirms Medvedev’s official testimony that he

79. Iurovskii, “Zapiska,” 31.

80. Iurovskii, “Iz rasskaza,” 110.

81. Bykov, “Poslednie dni poslednogo tsaria,” 21.

82. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 134. In contrast, Iurovskii in his 1934 account insists that “although the room was very small, everyone could have entered the room and the shooting proceed in an orderly manner” (провести расстрел в порядке). “Iz rasskaza,” 110.

83. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 237. Wilton accepted the idea that there were twelve murderers. Wilton, *Last Days*, 89; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 309.

84. O’Conor has suggested that Bykov’s article published in 1921 was in response to the publication of Wilton’s book, and that Bykov’s book published in 1926 was in response to the publication of Sokolov’s book. O’Conor explains that “[i]t almost seems as though the Bolsheviks were unwilling to commit themselves until after having been assured of what the White in-

did not take part in the shooting and refutes what Medvedev told his wife and others.

There is another unusual yet significant point that Halliburton/Ermakov and Iurovskii are in agreement on, and that is what Nicholas said when Iurovskii read the death sentence. Both report that the tsar responded with the double question: "What? What?"⁸⁵ Halliburton/Ermakov then adds: "aren't we going to get out of here after all?" This last question is similar to what both Bykov⁸⁶ and the "Memoirs" report. Presumably Halliburton could have been told by someone (the translator Walter?) what was in Bykov's article. But neither Bykov nor the "Memoirs" nor any other testimony, besides that of Iurovskii's 1920 report (which Halliburton could not have known), mentions the double interrogative pronouns. Of the versions available to Halliburton, the closest reporting of a similar response can be found in the testimony of F. P. Proskuriakov, but he reports only one "Что?"⁸⁷ Proskuriakov said he obtained this information from Medvedev, who, although not present at the time, may have obtained some sense of this from Ermakov later (we know that Medvedev talked to Ermakov after the assassination). In the British edition of Wilton's book, the "Что?" of Proskuriakov's testimony is translated as "What does this mean?" whereas in the American edition it is translated as "What?"⁸⁸ Thus, Halliburton could not have obtained "What? What?" (Что? Что?) from the only versions of the English translation available to him of Proskuriakov's testimony, nor is it likely he knew of this Russian colloquialism. Nor could he have obtained it from Iurovskii's report, which was not published until 1989. We must conclude that he obtained it from Ermakov himself who heard the same thing that Iurovskii heard. In contrast, the "tak nas nykuda ne povezut" that Bykov attributes to Nicholas and that shows up in the "Memoirs" would have been available to anyone who could read Russian and was writing in Sverdlovsk after 1921, the date of publication of Bykov's account. This phrase would not have been available to Halliburton, however, in any translated material. How Bykov found out about this phrase we do not have enough evidence to say. But we might speculate that Iurovskii told him, then

investigators had found and of what the final conclusions of those investigators were to be." O'Connor, "Translator's Commentary," 8. But in 1921 Bykov went beyond what information Wilton provided by writing that Ermakov was in charge and that four men were involved in the shooting. Sokolov did not suggest a number but inferred that there were four: Iurovskii, Ermakov, Vaganov, and Medvedev. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 218–19. This may be a case of Bykov's influencing Sokolov's conclusions rather than Sokolov's influencing Bykov's.

85. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 31. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 139. In his 1934 account, Iurovskii is recorded as stating that Nicholas said only one "Что?" "Iz rasskaza," 110.

86. Bykov, "Poslednie dni poslednogo tsaria," 21: "так нас нигде не повезут?"

87. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 224; Sokoloff, *Enquête judiciaire*, 260.

88. Wilton, *Last Days*, 305; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 154.

neglected to put it in his report. It is also possible that Ermakov had read Bykov's account and added it to his own recollection.

Normally, the existence of memoirs would serve to discredit or at least counter an interview, especially since the question of whether the interview ever took place has not yet been decisively answered. In this case, however, the faultiness of the testimony in the "Memoirs" has the opposite effect of discrediting that testimony. There are too many differences between the account in the "Memoirs" and that given by Ermakov in the interview for me to accept the idea that until 1934 Ermakov accurately remembered what had happened, then, by 1947, simply forgot it, and even forgot what he had said thirteen years earlier. This raises the question of why Ermakov, if he did write the "Memoirs," would intentionally falsify his own account. Could it have been written in response to Halliburton's interview in order to save Ermakov himself for having given an interview to a foreign journalist without permission? Perhaps Ermakov thought he was dying when he met Halliburton, but unexpectedly recovered. He could then point to the falsified account as evidence that he had not given the interview or had provided Halliburton the wrong information. This scenario is highly unlikely for the simple reason that Ermakov would not wait until 1947 to deposit his "Memoirs" in the Party Archives if he was concerned about retribution for granting the interview. By 1947, the Halliburton interview would no longer have been a concern. Instead, the "Memoirs" are most likely forged by someone who was not an eyewitness to the events being described, and may have been written for another purpose.

In 1934, Ermakov was placed on pension because of illness.⁸⁹ The Ermakov who Halliburton interviewed spoke in "a hoarse and half-choking whisper" and was "straining and gasping for each word."⁹⁰ But Radzinsky writes that 1934–35 is the time frame in which Ermakov began making speeches to Young Pioneer groups.⁹¹ Nikolai Ross reports that an acquaintance "who studied in Sverdlovsk in the 1940's" told him that "Ermakov visited the local schools and recounted to the children how he, with his own hands, had killed the members of the tsar's family."⁹² And someone was collecting Ermakov's pension until 1952. In order to continue collecting their pensions, Old Bolsheviks were required to write their memoirs. This would explain why memoirs attributed to Ermakov were deposited in the Sverdlovsk Archives in 1947. But the person who wrote the "Memoirs" cannot be the same person who Halliburton interviewed in 1934. If someone else wrote

89. Borovikov and Gavrilov, "Rasstreliany proletarskoi rukoi," 174.

90. Halliburton, *Seven League Boots*, 107, 109.

91. Radzinsky, *Last Tsar*, 397.

92. *Gibel' tsarskoi sem'i* (Ross), 586 n. 5.

Ermakov's "Memoirs" for him in 1947, then Ermakov must not have read or corrected the text. But if the throat cancer that Halliburton describes was not a trick, as Radzinsky supposed, then we must accept the fact that the Ermakov who took part in the murder of the Romanovs died at the end of 1934 or the beginning of 1935 at the latest. But there was pension money to be had, and, we might suggest, in a Martin Guerre-type switch, someone else, who had not taken part in the shooting, began passing himself off as Ermakov. If one accepts the authenticity of the Halliburton interview, as I do, then one is led inexorably to consider this possibility. Those who do not accept the authenticity of the interview need to explain how Halliburton could have concocted an account of the murders in 1935 that coincides with Iurovskii's own official report and subsequent narration in a number of significant details, while one of the assassins could not do so in 1947.

There are also internal textual reasons to accept Halliburton's account of his interview with Ermakov as providing reliable evidence about the disposing of the bodies. Except for one finger, no remains of the victims were found at the Four Brothers mine shaft, which led to speculation that some of the family escaped the massacre. According to Richard Pipes, "[t]he mystery was cleared up only with the publication of Iurovskii's memoir, from which it transpires that the bodies were buried at Four Brothers only temporarily."⁹³ According to both Iurovskii's 1920 report, published in 1989, and his 1934 account, published in 1993, the bodies were moved, two of them were burned with gasoline, and all were disfigured with sulphuric acid.⁹⁴ Then the remains were placed in a grave two-and-a-half arshins (or about six feet) deep. This description of the moving of the bodies from the Four Brothers mine shaft and subsequent burning coincides with what Ermakov told Halliburton in 1934. So, the mystery was cleared up over fifty years earlier, but the explanation was ignored.⁹⁵ In comparison, Bykov wrote that, after the bodies were burned with gasoline and sulphuric acid at the Four Brothers, the remains were carried some distance from the mine shaft and buried in mud.⁹⁶ Interestingly enough, the "Memoirs" also report that the bodies were moved but then completely destroyed, not buried.⁹⁷ Such information the memoirist could have obtained from Ermakov's wife, who was present at the Halliburton interview.

93. Pipes, *Russian Revolution*, 779.

94. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 32; idem, "Iz rasskaza," 116.

95. Actually the answer to the mystery was available in 1919, because Wilton reports hearing "the bodies had been buried in one place, then re-buried in another." But he dismissed these as "versions carefully sown by agents of Yurovsky, who remained in the city. . . ." Wilton, *Last Days*, 106; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 334.

96. Bykov, *Poslednie dni Romanovykh*, 126. In his article published five years earlier, Bykov made no mention of how the bodies were disposed of.

97. "Vospominaniia," 183.

The interview with Ermakov differs from Iurovskii's account on three main points concerning the disposal of the bodies: the direction the bodies were taken (Ermakov says 2 km further along the road to Koptiaki; Iurovskii's report indicates the opposite direction back toward Ekaterinburg in order to reach the Moscow road); the number of bodies burned (Ermakov says all of them; Iurovskii reports only two — Aleksei and Anna Demidova); and whether the bodies were completely destroyed (Ermakov says all the bodies were reduced to powder that was scattered to the winds, whereas Iurovskii says two of them were cremated and the remains of nine others were buried). There are also other substantial differences between the two accounts regarding events during the thirty-six hours following the assassination.

Iurovskii's assertion that remains were buried coincides in general terms with what Bykov wrote. Bykov, however, was not present at the cremation of the bodies and may have obtained his version from Iurovskii. Ermakov stated that Iurovskii stayed behind the first night to set the house in order, and makes it clear that he (Ermakov) was in charge of the bodies. Sokolov concluded that Ermakov was in charge of the bodies because he knew the area and Iurovskii did not. Bykov also places Ermakov in charge of the bodies, but that may be for the same unknown reason he put Ermakov and not Iurovskii in charge of the actual killing. Bykov must have known that Iurovskii was in charge of the killing since he (Iurovskii) was given the order to execute the Romanovs by the Ural Soviet in person. Iurovskii puts himself in charge of the bodies. Yet he was away the entire next day looking for another place to bury them.⁹⁸ Thus, one can raise the question whether the accounts of Iurovskii and Bykov may not be as reliable as what Ermakov told Halliburton in this regard, which happens to coincide with Sokolov's conclusion that all the bodies had been completely destroyed. On the other hand, Ermakov could not have cremated the bodies until 18 July when Iurovskii returned from Ekaterinburg with the gasoline and sulphuric acid. From then on, Iurovskii was with the bodies until they were buried. Besides, Ermakov would have no reason to tell a young American reporter there were bodies to be found. The Soviet regime was only seventeen years old at that point. While pro-tsarist movements had been quashed for some time, there was no telling what problems might be created if remains of the imperial family were unearthed. Furthermore, the complete destruction of eleven bodies was probably beyond the crude resources available to Ermakov and Iurovskii, but the reduction to ash of two bodies was within their means.

Summers and Mangold disputed Sokolov's conclusion that sulphuric acid was effective in destroying the bodies. In support of their view, they cited the testimony of two individuals, Professor Francis Camps, a forensic expert, and

98. Iurovskii, "Zapiska," 31; idem, "Iz rasskaza," 113–15.

Dr. Edward Rich of the U. S. Military Academy at West Point.⁹⁹ But the type of sulphuric acid that Camps and Rich were referring to is the diluted type used in most chemistry labs. The concentrated type that was available to Ermakov came from the platinum industry in Ekaterinburg. Diluted sulphuric acid would not be sufficient for working with platinum or for dissolving bones and teeth. In addition, concentrated sulphuric acid, when it comes in contact with flesh, which is made up of 75 percent water, manufactures a tremendous amount of heat on its own, sufficient together with gasoline to create the 1500°F temperature needed to cremate bones and teeth. In addition, neither Camps nor Rich takes into consideration the amount of gasoline and sulphuric acid available to Ermakov. Sokolov found receipts and orders for 11 puds and 4 funts of sulphuric acid (about 20 gallons according to Bulygin).¹⁰⁰ An eyewitness estimated the amount of gasoline at 40 puds of gasoline (about 170 gallons according to Bulygin).¹⁰¹ The sulphuric acid would also have the effect of carbonizing the calcium in the bones and teeth and, thus, of making them more susceptible to being further broken down by fire.¹⁰² Therefore, with the means available to them, it was physically possible for Iurovskii and Ermakov to destroy at least two bodies completely.

It would have been Ermakov's little joke to tell Halliburton that the bodies were taken in the opposite direction from Four Brothers, that is further on toward Koptiaki, instead of back toward Ekaterinburg. And Ermakov would have just been continuing the deception by confirming Sokolov's conclusion that all the bodies had been cremated and their ashes scattered when only two had been so destroyed. One further irony is that the place where the remaining bodies were buried according to Iurovskii was a place that Sokolov had a photograph of in his book.¹⁰³ It was where Iurovskii and Ermakov had put down railroad ties over the buried corpses not only to hide them but to give the appearance of creating a corduroy section to facilitate vehicle crossing of a

99. Summers and Mangold, *File on the Tsar*, 153–56.

100. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 204–5; Paul Bulygin, *The Murder of the Romanovs: The Authentic Account* (New York: Robert M. McBride, 1935), 249. The amount of sulphuric acid used was enough to cause a deficiency in the city's supply for at least a year. Wilton reported that in 1919 he could not get a platinum ring made in Ekaterinburg because, as he was told, there had been no sulphuric acid "since the previous year." Wilton, *Last Days*, 101; Telberg and Wilton, *Last Days*, 327.

101. Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, 205; Bulygin, *Murder of the Romanovs*, 249.

102. I wish to thank Dr. James Davis of the Chemistry Department of Harvard University, E. P. Caggiano of E. P. Caggiano & Son, and Morris Schopf of Schopf Design Associates for discussing these matters with me.

103. Iurovskii states this in his 1934 account. See "Iz rasskaza," 116. For the picture Iurovskii refers to, see Sokolov, *Ubiistvo tsarskoi sem'i*, photo no. 76 (between pp. 208 and 209).

muddy place in the road. It was a place that Sokolov must have crossed countless times and never thought to look beneath the *cor du roi*.

The eyewitness accounts do differ in their reliability depending on which stage of the process they discuss. On the events of the night immediately preceding the shooting, both Medvedev's depositions and the Halliburton/Ermakov account are more accurate and detailed than Iurovskii's accounts. On the shooting itself, the Halliburton/Ermakov interview is the most accurate version. Medvedev did not see it happen and Iurovskii's accounts give the impression of his being in a bit of a fog. On the disposal of the bodies, Iurovskii's accounts are the most accurate because Medvedev did not take part and Ermakov was most likely deceiving Halliburton. While Ermakov certainly had a motive to deceive Halliburton about the final disposition of the bodies, he had no similar motive to lie about the events of the night preceding the killing and the killing itself. About those events and about the initial attempts to dispose of the bodies, we can accept his account as accurate.

Finally, throughout Halliburton's career, doubts were raised about the veracity of his stories. Halliburton, although acknowledging that he did tend to embroider with extravagant prose, insisted that the facts of his stories were fundamentally accurate. As he once told his father: "When I say I did something, I actually did it. But I splash a little red paint on it to make it more interesting."¹⁰⁴ How much "red paint" did Halliburton splash on his reporting of the Ermakov interview? After sifting through the evidence, I would have to say that there is very little "red paint" here. In a letter he wrote just after the interview, Halliburton himself described the story that Ermakov told him as "unguarded, complete and terrifically vivid."¹⁰⁵ It required no embroidery. The story was spectacular enough just as Ermakov told it to him.

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104. Quoted in David M. Schwartz, "On the Royal Road to Adventure with 'Daring Dick'," *Smithsonian*, March 1989, 170.

105. Halliburton, *His Story of His Life's Adventure*, 360.

TABLE 1: A Comparison of Accounts of the Assassination

	<i>Medvedev</i> (1918/1920)	<i>Bykov</i> (1921)	<i>Halliburton</i> (1934/35)	<i>"Memoirs"</i> (1947)	<i>Iurovskii</i> (1920/1989)	<i>Iurovskii</i> (1934/1993)
<i>When awakened</i>	Around midnight	Around 10:00 P.M.	Shortly after midnight	11:00 P.M.	After 1:30 A.M.	After 1:30 A.M.
<i>Number brought down</i>	—	10	12	11	12	[12]
<i>Number of chairs</i>	3	—	3	11	2	2
<i>Number of executioners in the room</i>	11	4	3	—	komand	—
<i>Who was in charge?</i>	Iurovskii was in charge	Ermakov organized the shooting; Iurovskii read the decree	Iurovskii was in charge and impatient	Iurovskii was hesitant, reluctant; Ermakov took charge	Iurovskii was in charge and impatient	Iurovskii was in charge; mentions anxiety
<i>What kind of weapons?</i>	Iurovskii had a Mauser; the rest had Nagants	—	Ermakov had a Mauser; Iurovskii had a pistol	Ermakov had a Mauser; the rest had Nagants	All had Nagants*	All had Nagants*
<i>Nicholas's last words</i>	—	так нас никуда не повезут?	What? What? Aren't we going to get out of here after all?	как нас никуда не повезут?	Что? Что?	Что?

*In a ca. 1927 document, Iurovskii stated that he had a Colt and his assistant had a Mauser.